it.’ After this encounter, Nott grew increasingly sceptical about the reception Shah Shuja would receive. ‘I differ from the government and the others, and I really believe that the people of Afghanistan will not give up their country without fighting for it,’ he observed. ‘I know I would not, were I in their situation.’[44]

Other officers had similar conversations. Lieutenant Thomas Gaisford’s Indian orderly was asked by one Pashtun visitor to the camp, ‘“Do they really call these Feringhees, ‘Sahibs’ [Sir]?” The inquirer asked in such a way as if he thought “Dog of an Infidel” might have been a more appropriate appellation.’[45] ‘We fell in with a well-dressed Afghan horseman,’ wrote George Lawrence, a bright young Ulsterman whom Macnaghten had just promoted to be his military secretary. ‘He told me he had visited our camp, and seen our troopers, saying with much contempt, “You are an army of tents and camels: our army is one of horses and men.” “What can induce you”, he added, “to squander crores of rupees in coming to a poor rocky country like ours, without wood or water, and all in order to force upon us a *kumbukht* [an unlucky rascal] as a king, who the moment you turn your backs, will be upset by Dost Mohammad, our *own* king?”’[46] In time the horseman’s predictions would prove quite correct and when the rebellion did break out, it would be Achakzais from this region who would be in the vanguard.

Nott may have been impressed with the Afghans, but he was less taken with his own colleagues. It was around this time that the Commander-in-Chief Sir John Keane arrived in the camp and decided to promote General Willshire, a Queen’s officer, over the much more senior and experienced Nott, so giving Willshire command of the whole of the Company’s Bombay sepoy infantry. Though he had long suspected something of the sort would happen, and was inured by now to being passed over on account of his humble origins and the lack of prestige of the Company regiments relative to those of the regular army, Nott was still furious. He immediately confronted the Commander-in-Chief in his tent. The interview was very short, and went very badly:

‘I see I am to be sacrificed because I happen to be senior to the Queen’s officers,’ said Nott.

‘Ill impression Sir!’ replied Keane. ‘You insult my authority. I will never forgive your conduct as long as I live!’